

Orwell, Grice, and Political Euphemism: Pragmatic Misrepresentation in U.S. Immigration Discourse

1. Introduction

Political language... is designed to make lies sound truthful and murder respectable, and to give an appearance of solidity to pure wind.

George Orwell, *Politics and the English Language* (265)

In today's political landscape, Orwell's diagnosis resonates more than ever. Contemporary political discourse repeatedly seeks to render events digestible in order to justify or normalize policies that would otherwise provoke moral resistance. Misrepresentation, however, is not always perceived as lying. Political language often operates by diminishing the perceived importance of events, downplaying responsibility, or obscuring violence through euphemism and abstraction.

As Leth notes, drawing on Soames and Grice, there is a persistent temptation to treat what is conversationally implicated as if it were the real assertion of an utterance. Discussing Grice's recommendation-letter example, Soames observes that "the whole purpose of using indirect means to convey this information [i.e. the implicature] was to avoid having to state it" (Soames 443; cf. Kölbel 70). This remark itself implicates an important advantage of indirectness: speakers can guide interpretation while avoiding full responsibility for what is communicated. Among theorists of lying, this view—that indirectness allows speakers to evade accountability—is relatively widespread (Leth 2022: 130).

This advantage of not stating information directly is central to understanding asymmetrical power relations in political discourse. Euphemism and abstraction function as privileged tools of dominance: by hiding or neutralizing the force of war atrocities, detention practices, or political repression, speakers gain interpretive control over how events are perceived.

In this paper, I examine how this mechanism operates in the context of U.S. immigration policy under the Trump administration, focusing in particular on the rhetoric surrounding the deployment of Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE). By comparing official policy language with reports of practices on the ground, the analysis highlights a gap between what is communicated and what is materially enacted.

This case is especially instructive for a pragmatic analysis of misrepresentation. The strong public backlash these days against ICE practices reveals not only political conflict, but also the linguistic conditions that make such practices initially acceptable or tolerable within public discourse. Drawing on Grice's theory of conversational implicature (1975) and Orwell's critique of political prose (1946), this essay shows how political language can remain truth-conditionally accurate while being pragmatically misleading. Euphemistic formulations exploit conversational expectations—particularly those governing relevance, quantity, and manner—without requiring speakers to assert falsehoods.

The essay develops two case studies. The first examines administrative and carceral practices, analyzing how euphemistic terminology frames detention, confinement, and enforcement as neutral or procedural. The second focuses on categorization and naming, exploring how terms such as "alien" or "non-citizen" function pragmatically to dehumanize migrants and normalize exclusion. Together, these cases illustrate how political discourse preserves formal truth while generating misleading implicatures that distance speakers and audiences from ethical responsibility.

The concluding discussion briefly addresses the moral and political consequences of such practices, considers why pragmatic misrepresentation is difficult to detect, and reflects on the implications for media literacy and political responsibility in contemporary U.S. society.

2. Orwell and the Misuse of the English Language

Several years before publishing 1984, a dystopian novel that famously explores how language can be manipulated, reduced, and reshaped into a form of Newspeak that enables social and political control, George Orwell had already developed a sustained critique of political language and its capacity to distort thought. Orwell was deeply concerned with the malleability of language and with the ways in which habitual linguistic practices can be used to obscure truths, suppress responsibility, or distance speakers from the realities they describe. In his 1946 essay *Politics and the English Language*, Orwell argues that modern English prose—particularly political writing—has undergone a process of degradation characterized by vagueness, abstraction, and imprecision.

Orwell famously describes political prose as marked by “a mixture of vagueness and sheer incompetence,” observing that “as soon as certain topics are raised, the concrete melts into the abstract” (Orwell 255). Instead of selecting words for the sake of their meaning, writers increasingly rely on prefabricated expressions, producing prose that is assembled mechanically rather than thoughtfully. This movement away from concreteness is not stylistic alone: it prevents both writers and readers from forming clear mental representations of the situations being described.

Crucially, Orwell’s critique does not rest on the claim that political language is necessarily false. Rather, he shows how abstraction and euphemism make it possible to describe morally troubling actions without confronting their implications.

In that sense, political writing can remain truth-conditional while still obscuring responsibility and agency. As Orwell later illustrates, acts of violence may be linguistically reframed in ways that avoid calling up mental images—villages are “pacified,” populations are “transferred,” and opponents are “eliminated” (Orwell 261). Such expressions do not deny what has occurred, but they prevent the audience from fully grasping what is being represented.

To explain this deterioration, Orwell identifies several recurring linguistic devices: dying metaphors, verbal “false limbs,” pretentious diction, and meaningless words (Orwell 255–57). Although diverse in form, these devices share a common function: they reduce the cognitive effort required to think precisely. By relying on ready-made phrases, speakers no longer actively construct meaning, and listeners are discouraged from critically engaging with what is said. As Orwell warns, this process can even conceal meaning from the speaker himself, producing a reduced state of awareness that is particularly favorable to political conformity.

Orwell’s critique is powerful precisely because it identifies a form of misrepresentation that does not rely on outright falsehood. However, Orwell’s critique operates primarily at a diagnostic and normative level. While Orwell convincingly shows that political language obscures responsibility through abstraction and euphemism, he does not provide a systematic account of how such language succeeds communicatively. In particular, Orwell does not really explain how audiences are guided toward certain interpretations while speakers retain deniability, nor how misleading effects can arise even when utterances remain truth-conditionally accurate. To account for these mechanisms, a pragmatic framework is required—one that can explain how meaning is generated beyond what is explicitly said. Grice’s theory of conversational implicature offers precisely such a framework.

This theoretical limitation becomes clearer when Orwell's account of abstraction and imagery is examined more closely. A central dimension of Orwell's critique concerns the directionality of meaning in political language. Orwell repeatedly insists that clear thinking requires allowing "the meaning [to] choose the word, and not the other way about" (Orwell 264). When this process is reversed, language no longer serves as a tool for expressing thought but instead begins to structure and constrain it. Euphemism and abstraction, on this view, do not merely obscure reality retrospectively; they actively guide interpretation in advance by delimiting which meanings are made cognitively available to the audience. In this sense, political language does not merely distort what is thought, but constrains what can plausibly be thought at all.

This concern is closely tied to Orwell's emphasis on mental imagery. Orwell insists that writers should first form "a rough mental picture of the object or idea" before selecting words (Orwell 264), an injunction that is not merely aesthetic but aimed at resisting the misleading effects of abstract political prose. By contrast, abstract language encourages speakers to rely on words from the outset, allowing "the existing dialect" to take over at the expense of precision (Orwell 264). The result is a blurring—or even alteration—of meaning. Abstraction thus operates not simply as a stylistic preference, but as a cognitive shortcut that weakens the link between linguistic expression and mental representation.

From this perspective, euphemistic political language functions as a form of representational attenuation. By avoiding vivid imagery, it prevents audiences from forming clear mental pictures of what is being described, thereby reducing the emotional and moral salience of events. Orwell insists that writers should think "through pictures or sensations" before selecting words (Orwell 264), an injunction that is not merely aesthetic but a response to the risk of misrepresentation inherent in abstract political prose. Where imagery is suppressed, interpretation becomes more malleable and more easily guided by institutional or ideological interests.

Orwell's analysis anticipates a central insight later formalized in relevance theory. When Orwell argues that euphemistic phraseology allows speakers to "name things without calling up mental pictures," he identifies a cognitive mechanism through which political language limits what becomes salient or emotionally accessible to an audience (Orwell 261–62). Sperber and Wilson provide a theoretical account of this effect, defining a fact as manifest to an individual only insofar as it can be mentally represented and accepted as true or probable (Sperber & Wilson 39). Read together, these accounts suggest that euphemistic political language does not merely rename events, but actively restricts the mental representations available to audiences, thereby reducing the manifestness of violence and responsibility.

Overall Orwell stylistic rules—such as avoiding stale metaphors, unnecessary passives, jargon, and prefabricated expressions (Orwell 264)—can be read in this light as safeguards against indirectness that obscures commitment. Although Orwell does not theorize reported speech or indirect communication explicitly, his critique implicitly targets linguistic practices that allow speakers to distance themselves from what is communicated. Ready-made phrases and abstract constructions enable speakers to express attitudes or evaluations without fully committing to them, thereby attenuating responsibility for the interpretations that audiences are encouraged to draw.

This concern can be read as anticipating later pragmatic discussions of misrepresentation, particularly those centered on indirectness and deniability (Grice; Leth). Misrepresentation, on such accounts, arises when a speaker makes it appear as though an original agent—or the speaker themselves—is committed to a proposition they have not explicitly endorsed. Orwell's objection to abstraction and euphemism can thus be understood as an early diagnosis of a communicative strategy that allows speakers to guide interpretation while avoiding explicit assertion. Political

language, in his words, is “designed to make lies sound truthful and murder respectable, and to give an appearance of solidity to pure wind” (Orwell 266).

Orwell’s critique is therefore not only a general diagnosis of political language, but directly relevant to the kind of institutional discourse examined in this essay. The euphemistic and abstract formulations he criticizes are precisely the linguistic resources through which contemporary state practices are rendered administratively neutral and morally tolerable. In the case studies that follow, particularly the analysis of U.S. immigration rhetoric surrounding Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE), such formulations do not function merely as stylistic choices, but as pragmatic strategies that shape how detention, deportation, and exclusion are interpreted. Orwell helps identify the effects of this language—its capacity to suppress imagery, attenuate responsibility, and distance audiences from violence—but a pragmatic framework is required to explain how these effects are achieved in communication. It is at this point that Grice’s theory of conversational implicature becomes essential, allowing us to analyze how political language can remain truth-conditionally accurate while nevertheless guiding interpretation in misleading ways.

3. Theoretical framework, Grice.

Thoughts without content are empty; intuitions without concepts are blind.

Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason* (A51/B75)

In *Critique of Pure Reason* (1781), Kant famously argued that intelligible thought depends on the coordination of conceptual structure and cognitive uptake. Understanding, on this view, is not generated by raw intuition alone, but by the application of rational constraints that make experience intelligible. Although Kant’s concern is epistemological rather than linguistic, this conception of intelligibility as dependent on shared rational conditions anticipates later accounts of communication.

In an article titled *Logic and Conversation* (1975), Grice formalizes an analogous assumption at the level of language through the Cooperative Principle, according to which participants are expected to make their contributions appropriate to the purposes of the exchange (Grice 26). This principle is operationalized through a set of conversational maxims governing informativeness, truthfulness, relevance, and clarity (Grice 47).

Explicitly “echoing Kant,” Grice organizes these maxims under four categories—Quantity, Quality, Relation, and Manner—which articulate the expectations speakers and hearers rely on for communication to succeed (Grice 45). Although Grice does not ground his theory in Kantian epistemology, later commentators argue that the Cooperative Principle can be understood as a rational constraint on communication analogous to Kant’s conditions of intelligibility (Schamberger and Bülow 705–07).

Grice shows in particular how conversational exchanges rely on these maxims to remain coherent and interpretable (Grice 47). The question of misrepresentation through euphemism is especially relevant here, since euphemistic language does not necessarily alter truth-conditions but instead exploits the Cooperative Principle by manipulating expectations of relevance, informativeness, and clarity. Euphemism operates by shifting attention away from what would otherwise be the most salient aspects of an utterance, allowing meanings to be softened or displaced without being explicitly denied. In this respect, Grice provides an explanatory framework for processes that Orwell had already identified and criticized, but not yet analyzed in pragmatic terms.

It is therefore important to analyze Grice’s framework in connection with Orwell in order to understand the mechanisms through which euphemism functions. What matters is not only how

euphemism works, but how it works within language itself, as part of ordinary communicative practice rather than as an external distortion. Euphemism generates implicature not by stating falsehoods, but by relying on conversational expectations about relevance, informativeness, and clarity. Political language, for instance, may acknowledge violence only at the level of implicature—often through understatement or litotes—so that its most troubling aspects remain present without being openly articulated.

This is why a pragmatic analysis is required to demystify such political language. Only by examining how conversational principles are exploited can we begin to dismantle the tools of misrepresentation and manipulation at work, especially when political discourse functions performatively, encouraging acceptance or compliance without explicit argument. As we have seen, Orwell echoes this concern when he exposes how the aporias of English political prose shape perception itself, guiding how events are understood while avoiding direct moral confrontation.

I will therefore begin by outlining Grice's account of conversational implicature before comparing it to Orwell's critique of political language and bringing the two together through contemporary case studies.

To start with, Grice's example of a clash between the maxims of Quantity and Quality illustrates how speakers may withhold information without deceiving their interlocutors (Grice 51). Using Grice's framework, when B answers "Somewhere in the South of France," the response is insufficiently informative for A's purposes, thereby violating the maxim of Quantity. However, this violation is motivated by B's commitment to the maxim of Quality: providing more precise information would require asserting something for which B lacks adequate evidence. The resulting implicature—that B does not know exactly where C lives—arises not from what is said, but from the assumption that the speaker remains cooperative (Grice 51). This mechanism helps explain how political euphemism, as analyzed by Orwell, can remain truth-conditionally accurate while pragmatically misleading, preserving formal truth while minimizing the perceived severity of events.

Secondly, Grice's discussion of the second maxim of Quantity is particularly relevant to political discourse, where speakers often provide more certainty and justificatory detail than the context strictly requires. Under cooperative conditions, a speaker who is confident that *p* could simply assert *p*; when a speaker instead becomes unusually voluble, the hearer is prompted to ask what communicative purpose the excess serves (Grice 49-50). As Grice notes, when a speaker provides "not only the information that *p*, but information to the effect that it is certain that *p*, and that the evidence for its being the case that *p* is so-and-so and such-and-such," this surplus may lead the hearer to doubt whether the speaker is "as certain as he says he is" (Grice 52-53). If the over-informativeness is interpreted as designed rather than accidental, it becomes "an oblique way of conveying that it is to some degree controversial whether or not *p*" (Grice 53). In political and media contexts, this helps explain how emphatic certainty can function pragmatically: it can project authority while simultaneously implicating the presence of contestation or public skepticism. In the context of ICE rhetoric examined in the following case studies, repeated assertions of necessity and public good increasingly generate distrust rather than compliance. The exaggeration required to sustain the nationalist narrative pragmatically implicates instability, prompting audiences to infer that such policies demand justification precisely because their legitimacy is fragile. What matters in both cases is not the truth of what is said, but the strategic exploitation of cooperative expectations. While the maxim of Quantity concerns how much information is provided or withheld, the maxim of Manner governs how that information is presented. Taken together, these maxims show how political language can remain formally cooperative while becoming pragmatically evasive. The case studies that follow examine how this dynamic operates both at the level of administrative practice and through the categorization of migrants in official discourse.

In another sense, Grice's account of non-straightforward interpretation clarifies why linguistic obstruction itself can carry meaning. As he argues, it would be "pointless" to impose unnecessary interpretive effort unless that difficulty were communicatively significant (Grice 55). When speakers violate the maxim of Manner by introducing obscurity or verbosity beyond what cooperation requires, the added complexity must therefore be doing pragmatic work. This explains why euphemistic and bureaucratic formulations do not merely obscure events, but actively distance speakers from their moral implications. Because conversational implicatures are cancellable, speakers can benefit from indirect meanings—such as the dilution of agency or responsibility—while retaining plausible deniability if challenged (Grice 57). Orwell identifies precisely this mechanism in political prose, where inflated language allows writers to "name things without calling up mental pictures," so that "words and meaning have almost parted company" (Orwell 261).

Grice's account of conversational implicature culminates in a insight: that meaning is not carried solely by what is said, but by the act of saying it in a particular way. As he stresses, "the implicature is not carried by what is said, but only by the saying of what is said, or by 'putting it that way'" (Grice 58). This distinction is especially important for understanding political euphemism, where linguistic form systematically obscures moral content while preserving the appearance of cooperation. Because conversational implicatures are cancellable, indeterminate, and not part of an expression's conventional meaning, they allow speakers to evade responsibility while still guiding interpretation.

This insight resonates closely with Orwell's critique of political prose. Orwell repeatedly draws attention to linguistic inflation—stale abstractions, accumulated negatives, and circumlocutions—that introduce complexity without precision. In such cases, he argues, "words and meaning have almost parted company," and language performs "the important service of partially concealing your meaning even from yourself" (Orwell 260). Read together, Grice and Orwell show that obstruction in language is not accidental but functional — and that its political danger lies not merely in misrepresentation, but in the gradual erosion of interpretive trust.

At this point, Grice's framework can be seen to have consequences that extend beyond interpretation itself, shaping political responsibility, accountability, and public trust. Grice's analysis of deliberate obscurity under the maxim of Manner further explains how this mechanism enables deniability. In his example, a speaker obscures an utterance in the presence of a third party while still intending their primary interlocutor to understand, generating the implicature that the information is not to be shared (Grice 56). Obscurity here does not block communication; it regulates access to meaning by presupposing different levels of interpretive entitlement. In political discourse, euphemism operates in a similar way: by avoiding explicit references to violence or responsibility, speakers preserve plausible deniability while positioning the public asymmetrically with respect to knowledge.

Because conversational implicatures are cancellable and non-detachable, such strategies allow speakers to benefit from indirect meanings—such as the dilution of agency or responsibility—while retaining the ability to retract those meanings if challenged (Grice 57). Over time, however, this instability between what is said and what is meant risks undermining trust itself. When citizens repeatedly encounter language that is formally cooperative yet pragmatically evasive, the result is not neutrality but suspicion. The case studies that follow examine how this erosion of trust becomes visible in institutional discourse, particularly in U.S. immigration rhetoric, where euphemism and abstraction function not only to manage interpretation but to sustain fragile claims to legitimacy.

3. Cases studies

We can see how lately ICE policy under the Trump administration has received strong backlash in the U.S.A. from the civil society, revealing a deeper discrepancy between official claims to act in the “national interest” and the human consequences of enforcement practices. Human Rights Watch (2025) documents that individuals held in ICE detention facilities were subjected to abusive conditions, including prolonged isolation, inadequate medical care, and practices that may amount to serious human rights violations. Physicians for Human Rights (2025) further shows that such forms of isolation produce severe psychological harm and meet internationally recognized criteria for cruel, inhuman, or degrading treatment.

While these reports document the consequences of detention practices in detail, they do not by themselves explain how such practices were rendered administratively normal, publicly acceptable, or linguistically defensible. Addressing that question requires attention not only to what is done, but to how it is described

The following section therefore develops two case studies drawn from U.S. immigration discourse under the Trump administration. While both concern the practices and rhetoric of Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE), they address distinct but interrelated dimensions of euphemistic misrepresentation.

The first case study focuses on administrative and carceral practices, examining how euphemistic terminology is used to frame detention, confinement, and enforcement as neutral or procedural.

The second case study shifts attention to categorization and naming, analyzing how terms such as “alien” or “non-citizen” function pragmatically to dehumanize migrants and normalize exclusion.

Together, these cases illustrate how political language can remain truth-conditionally accurate while generating misleading implicatures.

In what follows, I use the Grice–Orwell framework to show how this becomes digestible in public discourse: not necessarily by lying, but by controlling what is said vs. what is implicated, and by using bureaucratic abstraction to produce moral distance. The key point is that many official formulations remain truth-conditionally accurate, while still guiding interpretation in a way that minimizes cruelty, agency, and responsibility.

To do this, I compare (1) official terminology used by ICE and the administration, (2) the language used by critics (civil society, journalists, NGOs), and (3) what the report describes as the practical reality of detention.

Across U.S. immigration discourse, a set of recurring lexical substitutions functions as euphemistic “translation devices,” including pairs such as “administrative segregation” vs. “solitary confinement”; “non-citizen/alien” vs. “undocumented migrant/person”; “enforcement action” vs. “raid”; “unexpected death” vs. “killing”; and “detention facility” vs. “prison/jail.” These substitutions illustrate a broader pattern in which institutional language guides inference without asserting falsehood. The analytical question is not just “which term is nicer,” but what each term makes easy to infer.

While several euphemistic substitutions recur across U.S. immigration discourse, the first case study focuses on a single term—administrative segregation—in order to examine in detail how euphemism operates at the level of institutional practice.

3.1 Case Study 1: Administrative Euphemism and Carceral Practice

In U.S. immigration policy discourse, euphemistic terminology often operates through pragmatic implicature rather than semantic falsification. When official materials prefer terms such as “administrative segregation” instead of “solitary confinement,” or “detention facility” instead of “prison,” utterances can remain technically correct while exploiting the maxims of Manner and Quantity. The audience is thereby guided toward an implicature of procedural normality rather than punitive isolation, illustrating what Orwell describes as the moral distancing effect of bureaucratic abstraction.

This case study examines how such euphemistic terminology functions within U.S. immigration detention practices, focusing in particular on the use of administrative segregation in Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) detention standards and its pragmatic effects in public and institutional discourse.

According to ICE’s National Detention Standards (Revised 2025), solitary confinement is formally divided into two categories: administrative segregation and disciplinary segregation. Administrative segregation is described as non-punitive and is said to be used for safety or management purposes, including situations in which detainees are considered at risk of harming themselves or others (ICE National Detention Standards 52–53). Disciplinary segregation, by contrast, is presented as a punitive measure imposed following serious misconduct and a formal disciplinary process. This internal acknowledgment of punishment, however, coexists with ICE’s broader insistence that immigration detention as such is “non-punitive.” The effect of this structure is not simply inconsistency, but a strategic partitioning of responsibility: punishment is recognized at the level of isolated practices, while being denied at the level of the institution itself. By framing detention as a procedural necessity rather than a punitive system, ICE preserves the appearance of administrative neutrality even as coercive and harmful practices are carried out within it. Pragmatically, this allows detention to remain formally cooperative with legal and humanitarian norms, while minimizing the implicatures that would normally accompany acknowledged punishment.

At the level of truth-conditions, these descriptions are not necessarily false. Administrative segregation does exist as a formal category, and ICE does maintain internal distinctions between different forms of isolation. However, reports by Physicians for Human Rights (Cruelty Campaign 2025) demonstrate that the practical reality of administrative segregation in ICE detention closely resembles what is internationally recognized as solitary confinement (Cruelty Campaign 7–12). PHR documents widespread use of prolonged isolation, severe psychological harm, and the routine placement of detainees in segregated housing for reasons unrelated to safety, including retaliation for filing grievances or requesting basic necessities. These practices often affect particularly vulnerable populations, including individuals with preexisting medical or mental health conditions, despite ICE’s own directives that segregation be used only as a last resort (Cruelty Campaign 8).

From a Gricean perspective, the euphemistic force of administrative segregation operates not through semantic falsification but through pragmatic implicature. By choosing a bureaucratic and abstract term, ICE exploits the maxim of Manner, which favors clarity and avoids unnecessary vividness. The terminology suppresses salient features of the practice—such as prolonged isolation, sensory deprivation, and psychological harm—thereby guiding the audience toward an implicature of procedural normality. At the same time, the maxim of Quantity is satisfied only minimally: sufficient information is provided to maintain formal cooperation, while details that would foreground the severity of the practice are systematically omitted.

The resulting implicature is that segregation is a routine administrative tool rather than a coercive and harmful form of confinement. This allows detention practices to remain publicly defensible without requiring explicit denial of harm. As Orwell observes in his critique of political prose, such bureaucratic abstraction enables violence to be described “without calling up mental pictures,”

allowing moral responsibility to be displaced rather than confronted. In this case, linguistic distance functions as moral distance.

The pragmatic effect of this terminology extends beyond internal policy documents. When administrative segregation is presented as a non-punitive management tool in official standards, it becomes available for reuse in press releases, legal justifications, and political defenses of detention practices. In these contexts, the bureaucratic framing cues audiences to interpret isolation as routine governance rather than coercive confinement, thereby limiting public scrutiny and moral evaluation.

What is obscured, then, is not merely the fact of isolation, but its ethical significance. Because the language remains technically accurate, it preserves the appearance of institutional transparency while minimizing the perceived severity of the practice. This illustrates how political language can remain formally cooperative while becoming pragmatically evasive, maintaining legitimacy through abstraction rather than persuasion. The analysis of administrative segregation thus shows how euphemism operates at the level of institutional practice, preparing the ground for the second case study, which examines how similar mechanisms function in the categorization and naming of detained individuals themselves.

3.2 Case Study 2 : Categorization and Naming

While the first case study examined euphemism at the level of institutional practice, the second case study focuses on euphemism at the level of categorization and naming. In U.S. immigration discourse, the repeated use of terms such as “alien,” “illegal alien,” and “criminal alien” does more than describe legal status. These labels function pragmatically to shape how migrants are represented, evaluated, and morally positioned within public discourse.

From a Gricean perspective, such terminology remains largely truth-conditionally accurate: an “alien” is, in U.S. legal terminology, a non-citizen, and an “illegal alien” denotes an individual without authorized immigration status. However, the pragmatic force of these labels exceeds their legal content. By foregrounding illegality and otherness while omitting contextual information—such as length of residence, employment, family ties, or absence of criminal history—the language exploits the maxims of Quantity and Manner. Sufficient information is provided to sustain formal cooperation, while salient details that would complicate moral judgment are systematically excluded.

This effect is visible in ICE press releases, which routinely frame enforcement operations as targeting “egregious criminal alien offenders.” For example, an ICE statement describing a Maine enforcement operation reports the arrest of “illegal alien offenders” and emphasizes criminality as the defining feature of those detained (“ICE Arrests More Than 200 Illegal Aliens”). While such statements may be factually defensible at the level of legal classification, they generate implicatures of threat, danger, and necessity. The audience is invited to infer that those targeted pose an inherent risk, thereby rendering enforcement actions not merely justified but urgent.

Empirical reporting complicates this framing. A 2025 Guardian investigation documents that immigrants with no criminal record constitute the largest group currently held in ICE detention. Former Department of Homeland Security officials quoted in the report note that “criminal” is increasingly defined so broadly that undocumented status itself is treated as evidence of criminality, despite the absence of violent or serious offenses. As one official remarks, “These are hardworking people. These are not criminals” (Guardian, 26 Sept. 2025). The gap between official categorization and lived reality illustrates how euphemistic naming can remain legally accurate while pragmatically misleading.

This is where the notion of metarepresentation becomes crucial. When audiences are repeatedly invited to conceptualize migrants as “aliens,” the term does not merely denote legal status; it cues a broader representational framework. The label encourages audiences to model migrants as fundamentally outside the moral and political community, thereby reducing perceived obligations of care, empathy, or restraint. In this sense, the public is not simply informed but taught how to think about the target group. Once migrants are framed as outsiders by default, implicatures of threat, inevitability, and necessity become easier to draw from official statements.

The pragmatic consequences of this framing extend beyond language itself. As the Guardian reports, intensified enforcement has led to a rise in so-called “collateral arrests,” in which individuals without criminal records are detained simply for being present during enforcement actions. Here, categorization and practice reinforce one another: euphemistic naming makes expanded enforcement intelligible, while expanded enforcement retroactively appears to confirm the framing of migrants as inherently suspect. The result is not merely misrepresentation, but a reconfiguration of moral perception in which coercion appears administratively and ethically unremarkable.

Taken together, the two case studies show how euphemism operates across different levels of political discourse. In Case Study 1, bureaucratic abstraction distances audiences from the harms of confinement practices. In Case Study 2, categorical naming reshapes how subjects of those practices are perceived. In both cases, language remains formally cooperative and often truth-conditionally accurate, while generating implicatures that minimize responsibility, normalize exclusion, and sustain fragile claims to legitimacy.

4. Conclusion

In the mercantilist economy, the Pauper, being neither producer nor consumer, had no place: idle, vagabond, unemployed, he belonged only to confinement, a measure by which he was exiled and as it were abstracted from society.

Michel Foucault, *Madness and Civilization* (230)

To conclude, Michel Foucault’s analysis of confinement provides a historical resonance for the mechanisms examined in this essay. In *Madness and Civilization*, Foucault shows how confinement functioned not merely as a response to deviance, but as a process of abstraction through which certain populations were removed from social visibility and moral concern. Confinement, on this account, did not simply exclude individuals from society; it rendered them conceptually marginal, displaced from the sphere of ordinary ethical recognition.

The analysis developed here suggests that contemporary U.S. immigration discourse operates through a comparable logic. As the two case studies have shown, euphemistic language does not primarily function by stating falsehoods, but by shaping what becomes salient, inferable, and morally available to public interpretation. In the first case study, bureaucratic abstraction reframes coercive confinement as neutral administration. In the second, categorical naming such as “alien” or “criminal alien” restructures how migrants are conceptualized, positioning them outside the sphere of ordinary moral concern.

Orwell's critique helps diagnose the ethical effects of this abstraction, showing how language can suppress imagery and displace responsibility. Grice's theory of conversational implicature explains how this displacement is communicatively possible: by exploiting expectations of relevance, informativeness, and clarity, political language can remain truth-conditionally accurate while generating misleading implicatures. The resulting obstruction does not merely soften violence, but gradually erodes interpretive trust, as audiences are repeatedly invited to accept institutional narratives that minimize agency, harm, and accountability.

Seen in this light, the current backlash within U.S. civil society is not simply a reaction to policy outcomes, but a response to a deeper communicative failure. When official discourse persistently relies on abstraction and euphemism, it risks undermining the cooperative foundations on which political communication depends. The danger, as both Foucault and Orwell suggest, is not only that injustice is obscured, but that it becomes linguistically normalized—rendered intelligible, administratively routine, and ethically unremarkable.

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